I was just as impressed by him as a great human being, and we spent many hours discussing his interest in South Africa and wildlife. As a comparative youngster talking to an Australian legend, I was so pleased to discover we had so much in common.

Others will have shared similar experiences throughout the league with the result that, in my view, year by year, the IPL has gradually taken the intimidation factor out of international cricket.

It used to be huge. Whether you were playing in Kolkata or Brisbane or Leeds or Bridgetown, the fast bowler who was glowering at you after bowling a bouncer or the slip fielder who was constantly sledging you seemed scary because they were strangers, shadowy figures from a foreign land. But nowadays you are not going to be as easily intimidated by someone who, a few weeks earlier in an Indian hotel, was having a few beers with you and telling you about his children.

Most of the players now know each other so well, both as cricketers in a technical sense and as people, that some of the mystery and some of the edge have disappeared. What was once primarily a psychological contest has become a less complex, less layered test of skill between increasingly familiar foes.

I don't know whether this is a good thing or a bad thing, and it's probably a bit of both, and it may just be that I am getting old, but there do seem to be fewer surprises in the international game.

The IPL player auction was held in January 2011, ahead of the tournament, and I was signed by Royal Challengers Bangalore, then owned by Vijay Mallya, the extrovert entrepreneur and businessman. As players, we called him 'Boss' and, for many of us, he became an enthusiastic supporter and friend, a generous host who genuinely cared about the squad.

A few well-timed performances, notably a century from 59 balls while playing for South Africa in an ODI against India in Ahmedabad, may have increased my value but, whatever the reason, I was surprised and, frankly, a little embarrassed when the list of annual player salaries was published